



THE DIGITAL MALAWI ACCELERATION PROJECT

GRANT NUMBER:
PROJECT NUMBER:

IDA-E338-MW
P505095

Provision of a turnkey solution for the rehabilitation, upgrading, and commissioning of the Central Printing Facility including design, supply, installation and handover for full operational readiness

We received request for clarifications regarding the above captioned procurement activity and in the spirit of fairness and transparency, the clarifications together with the questions are shared in the Table below.

Table 1: Responses to requests to Clarifications

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
General	Following today's site visit in Lilongwe and considering the size, scope, and complexity of the project, additional time is required to complete the necessary technical assessments, engage with key subcontractors and technology partners, and develop a comprehensive, compliant, and competitive proposal that fully addresses the requirements of the RFP. To ensure that all bidders have sufficient time to prepare high-quality submissions and to promote broad and competitive participation, we respectfully request an extension of the proposal submission deadline by six (6) weeks	Bidders are advised that the second extension has been considered and the revised closing date for receipt of bids is 13 th October 2026. Bidders are advised that this is the final acceptable extension.
Page 137 / 1.3.1.1.2.1.3	The requirement indicates the bidder must provide We interpret 'graphical layout designer/editor for card template design' to be the final design files in editable format.	Bidders are advised that the graphical layout designer is required to redesign the Malawi National ID template for the polycarbonate

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	Can the Purchaser please confirm if our interpretation is correct or specify clearly the exact item(s) required for this provision?	cards. The Supplier shall work closely with the Purchaser to design the new blank ID card.
Page 138 / 1.3.1.1.2.2.2	The laser personalization control software requires the generation of a CLI (known as changeable laser image with left/right tilt). Can the Purchaser please confirm if generation of an MLI (known as multiple laser image with up/down tilt) is equally acceptable?	Bidders are advised that the generation of a CLI is the minimum requirement for this procurement, therefore, there is no problem if the proposed solution meets this minimum requirement and is also capable of generating an MLI with tilt.
Page 44 / I.T,P 1.1 and Pages 191-192 / A	The tender documents specify a project delivery period of 32 weeks. Can the Purchaser please confirm whether this timeframe includes the production and delivery of the 2 million polycarbonate cards, or whether these activities are to be scheduled separately?	Bidders are advised that the 32 weeks timeframe only covers the activities indicated in the Implementation Schedule on page 191 of the issued bidding document.
Page 170 / 3.4.5.1	In section 3.4.5.1 of the tender document, the RFP requires that "Samples shall be included in the bid submission and again during production testing." We interpret production testing with samples to occur after contract award, as part of the deployment activities. Can the Purchaser please confirm if our interpretation is correct, clarify when the samples must be provided	Bidders are advised that the samples required are images as indicated in the referred clause. 3.4.5.1 The firm shall provide sample card images demonstrating the exact layout, design and security features. Required samples include:
ITP 2.1: Page 44	ITP 2.1 of the tender documents indicates a Financing Agreement amount of US\$70 million. Can the Purchaser confirm whether this funding is intended exclusively for the provision of a turnkey solution for the rehabilitation, upgrading, and commissioning of the Central Printing Facility, including the design, supply, installation, commissioning, and handover necessary to achieve full operational readiness, as well as the supply of 2 million cards?	Bidders are advised that the US\$70 Million covers the entire 1 st Phase of the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project and not for the provision of a turnkey solution for the rehabilitation, upgrading, and commissioning of the Central Printing Facility, including the design, supply, installation, commissioning, and handover necessary to achieve full operational readiness
Section VII → Architectural Requirements → Mailing and Dispatch Management System	Mailing and Dispatch Scope Please outline the responsibilities involved in the mailing and dispatch process, including card-to-carrier matching, envelope insertion, mail verification, sorting, dispatch, courier coordination, tracking, proof of delivery, and delivery status updates to NRIS. Where applicable, please indicate whether each function is supported by the production management	Bidders are advised that the mailing system must package printed cards into envelopes marked with the destination address. Currently, the National Registration Bureau (NRB) dispatches these cards in batches to the ordering remote offices. The National Registration Information System (NRIS) tracks this process through a document tracking system, recording each card's status changes from "printing" to "ready for collection," at which point an SMS automatically alerts the cardholder. The proposed mailing and dispatch

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	system or provided by the mailing/courier service provider.	system must seamlessly enhance this existing delivery and notification pipeline.
Section VII → System Integration (to other existing systems); Section VII → Architectural Requirements → Integration Layer	Please provide NRIS interface specifications, including APIs, schemas, message formats, authentication, error handling, and test environments.	Bidders are advised that currently, the NRIS integrates with the existing card printers through a middleware application that connects directly to the database for the card printing process. NRB plans to develop an API for the personalization and mailing system.
Section VII → Disaster Recovery Architecture Plans; Backup and Recovery Requirements; Software Architecture (DR synchronization, failover).	Please define the required Disaster Recovery architecture, location, RTO, RPO, failover, and whether a complete secondary site is required.	Designing and implementing a secondary Disaster Recovery (DR) site is excluded from this project's scope. However, proposals must demonstrate full architectural readiness for future DR integration. Additionally, bidders must include a comprehensive backup and restoration plan for the proposed system and operational data that seamlessly utilizes the existing NRIS DR site.
Section VII → Personalization Laser Features ("600 dpi full colour"); Automatic Modular Laser Personalization Systems ("Greyscale Picture"); Polycarbonate Cards ("Stacked-Layer Grey Scale Personalization")	Please clarify whether the photo personalization requirement is full-colour or greyscale laser personalization.	The photo personalization requirement is greyscale laser personalization.
Section VII → Performance Requirements; Automatic Modular Laser Personalization Systems; OAT Test No. 3 (Production Throughput Compliance Test).	Please define the contractual throughput measurement methodology, including whether throughput is measured as gross machine output or accepted finished cards.	The expected throughput will be measured based on the accepted finished cards.
Section VII → Technology Specifications Page 165	Please confirm whether the national ID card contains a chip. If yes, provide the complete chip specification, operating system, applications, data groups, encoding requirements, PKI/certificate	For this procurement, the specifications for blank cards do not include chip requirements. Therefore, the card personalization system will use the PKI certificate for the generation of digitally signed QR code which contains biodata

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	requirements, key management responsibilities and acceptance tests.	and biometric details. The proposed personalization system's modular design must ensure compatibility with future chip encoding mandates as determined by the NRB.
1.5 / 1.3 / 3.1 1.5.2.1.2; 1.3.1.2.2.1.1; 3.1.2	Further to question 11 above regarding throughput measurement methodology, the stated throughput figures themselves appear inconsistent: clause 1.5.2.1.2 states a minimum of 1000 cards per hour per personalization line; clause 1.3.1.2.2.1.1 states 2000 cards per hour for the laser personalization systems; and clause 3.1.2 states duplex printing speed of not less than 2000 cards per hour with two machines. Can the Purchaser confirm the governing figure — specifically, is 2000 cards per hour the combined output of both machines or the output of each machine — and confirm the shift pattern and daily operating hours assumed for the 28,000 cards per day target in clause 1.5.2.1.1?	The combined throughput for two machines for personalization is at least 2000 cards per hour. This means one machine must have a throughput of at least 1000 cards per hour. Shift pattern: operations to run on two 7 hrs shifts per day.
3.3 / 1.5 3.3; 1.5.2.1.3	Clause 3.3 requires at least 2000 completed mailers per hour with two machines, while clause 1.5.2.1.3 requires 28,000 envelopes per day with two machines over two shifts. Can the Purchaser confirm the required per machine mailing throughput and the assumed daily operating window, and confirm the expected mix of 1, 2,3 and 4 cards per carrier letter for capacity sizing?	To match the printing throughput, each mailer must process at least 1,000 items per hour, based on an assumed daily operating window of two 7-hour shifts. Additionally, the number of cards per carrier letter will be agreed upon with NRB to determine the optimal number of cards per envelope for delivery.
1.5 / 1.6 1.5.2.5.1; 1.6.11.5	Clause 1.5.2.5.1 requires the Information System to support a minimum of 10 to 50 million identity records with 10–15-year retention, while clause 1.6.11.5 requires compliance with data minimization and purpose limitation principles. Can the Purchaser confirm whether the personalization system is expected to retain citizen identity data long term as a repository, or whether it should retain only production and audit data with identity data purged after successful issuance, with NRIS remaining the system of record?	It is recommended that the personalization system must only retain the production and audit data whilst the NRIS remains the system of records.
1.6 1.6.2.1; 1.6.11.4	Further to question 12 above regarding the chip and its associated PKI requirements, clause 1.6.2.1 requires digital signature enforcement for card personalization and clause 1.6.11.4 requires eIDAS-aligned digital signature standards — obligations that appear to apply whether or not the card	The e-Government department is responsible for PKI and certification within the Malawi Government. The Supplier shall not be required to deliver a new PKI solution; furthermore, the personalization system will use the PKI for the generation of secure digitally signed QR codes on the non-chip cards.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	carries a chip. Can the Purchaser clarify what must be digitally signed in the personalization process (production job files, card data records, or audit records), whether an existing NRB or Government of Malawi PKI/Certification Authority will issue the signing certificates or whether the Supplier is to deliver a new PKI, and who performs and witnesses the key ceremony?	
Section VII → Technology Specifications; System Inventory Tables 3.0–3.5; System Inventory Table (Supply and Installation Cost Items)	Clauses 1.3 to 1.6 require servers, enterprise database platforms with clustering and replication, HSMs, next generation firewalls, IDS/IPS, EDR, SIEM, backup storage and a monitoring stack, but none of these appear as priced items in the technology specifications (3.1–3.5) and the System Inventory Tables have been issued blank. Can the Purchaser confirm that all supporting ICT infrastructure, software licences and their three-year support are within the Supplier's supply scope and are to be added by the bidder to the System Inventory Tables,	The supporting ICT infrastructure, software licenses, and three-year support are within the Supplier's scope of supply and must be included in the system inventory tables. The Hardware Security Module (HSM) solution will be required to utilize the PKI when generating secure QR codes on the cards.
1.4 / 1.6 1.4.1.2; 1.6.3	Clause 1.4.1.2 requires the ability to deploy configurations across development, test and production environments and clause 1.6.3 requires data masking in non-production environments. Can the Purchaser confirm how many nonproduction environments are required (development, test/UAT, training, DR-test), whether they are to be colocated at NRB HQ, and whether separate physical or virtualized infrastructure is expected for each?	Following ICT best practices, the bidder must provide non-production environments for development, training and User Acceptance Testing (UAT). The bidder should recommend whether these additional environments should be hosted within the same card personalization system environment or colocated at the NRIS data center. Furthermore, the bidder may propose either a virtualized or physical infrastructure.
Section VII → Operational Acceptance Tests OAT Table B, Tests 2 and 17	Further to question 9 above regarding RTO and RPO, the Operational Acceptance Tests set system availability at $\geq 99\%$ as an acceptance criterion. Can the Purchaser confirm whether $\geq 99\%$ is also the contractual availability service level for the warranty and post-warranty periods, and define the measurement period, the calculation basis, and the permitted exclusions (planned maintenance windows, Purchaser-caused outages, NRIS unavailability, and utility power or telecommunications failure)?	The card personalization system must maintain an availability level of $\geq 99\%$ during both the warranty and post-warranty periods. Permitted exclusions from this requirement include scheduled maintenance windows, system outages, NRIS unavailability, and power or connectivity failures external to the card personalization system.
2.1 Section VII → System Integration	Further to question 8 above requesting the NRIS interface specifications, the Supplier is required to design, develop, test and	The NRIS is managed by the NRB, whose developers will build the required interfaces in coordination with the Supplier. Therefore, this

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
(to other existing systems)	deploy all NRIS interfaces and to analyze and map NRIS data structures. Can the Purchaser confirm the NRIS platform and its current vendor, confirm whether that vendor will be contractually obliged to support interface development and testing, state from what date an NRIS test environment with representative data will be available to the Supplier, and confirm who bears the cost and schedule impact of any change required on the NRIS side?	task carries no contractual obligations or costs for the Bidder.
2.1 / 3.3 Section VII → Mailing System Integration; Dispatch and Delivery Tracking; 3.3	Further to question 7 above regarding the split of mailing and dispatch responsibilities, clause 3.3 states that mailers are handed to courier services for last-mile delivery. Can the Purchaser identify the courier service provider(s), confirm whether they are already contracted by the Purchaser, provide their tracking API or data exchange specification, state the address data standard and completeness held in NRIS for address validation, and define the required workflow for returned or undeliverable mail?	There is no Courier contracted for the delivery of cards by NRB. In the current setup, NRB manages the delivery services to all card ordering sites using its own fleet and program. The NRIS has a document tracker system that keeps track of the card statuses: printing, dispatching and ready for collection and send an SMS to the owner once ready for collection. This document tracker can be interfaced with the Suppliers proposed solution that aims at enhancing the card delivery process. The proposed system must be ready for any integration with Courier systems for an enhanced card delivery system.
1.6 1.6.8; OAT Table B, Test 16	Clause 1.6.8 requires Security Operations Centre capability or integration with 24/7 monitoring of critical systems, SIEM, forensic capability and defined incident response, while Operational Acceptance Test 16 requires the Purchaser to operate the system without vendor dependency. Can the Purchaser clarify whether the Supplier is to establish a SOC for NRB and transfer it, integrate with an existing Government of Malawi SOC, or provide SOC services as a recurrent managed service, and whether the associated staffing is to be priced under the Recurrent Cost Items?	The Supplier must implement a Security Operations Center (SOC) for the proposed system as part of the deliverables. Following the handover period, the NRB will assume full responsibility for managing the SOC.
1.4 / 1.6 1.4.1.4; 1.6.4	Clauses 1.4.1.4 and 1.6.4 require a centralized IAM platform with RBAC, MFA, PAM, just-in-time provisioning and periodic access recertification, and the pre commissioning tests reference Active Directory integration. Can the Purchaser confirm whether NRB will provide directory services and an existing identity platform for the Supplier to integrate with, or whether the complete identity, MFA and	The NRB will provide its existing Active Directory (AD) system for integration. The Supplier must deliver a solution that implements industry-standard secure access controls in strict compliance with the specified minimum requirements.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	privileged access management platform is to be supplied as part of this contract?	
1.3 / 3.5 1.3.1.1.2.6.1; 3.5 (Secure Area Construction)	The renovation scope includes a secure blank card storage room, a consumables storage room and a secure destruction room, and the monitoring layer requires a stock management system for consumables. Can the Purchaser confirm whether serialized blank card inventory control — receipt, issue to production, reconciliation of spoilage and destruction, and stock to issuance balancing with reporting to NRIS — is required of the production management system, and specify any national audit or reconciliation standard the process must satisfy?	The Bidder must provide a serialized blank card inventory control system capable of interfacing with the NRIS. The system must ensure end-to-end traceability of each blank card throughout its entire lifecycle, from initial supplier delivery to its final issuance or disposal state.
3.5 3.5 (Site Assessment and Design; Civil and Architectural Works)	The bidder is required to conduct a site survey, verify existing infrastructure and produce detailed implementation drawings within the T+6 week design approval milestone. Following the site visit of 31 August 2026, can the Purchaser provide the existing architectural, structural, electrical, HVAC and floor layout drawings, state the available electrical load, existing UPS and generator capacity and fuel autonomy, state the incoming network connectivity to NRB HQ, and confirm whether any building permits, statutory approvals or landlord consents are the responsibility of the Purchaser or the Supplier?	The proposed solution must not rely on any existing electrical, ICT, or HVAC infrastructure. The Supplier is required to design and implement completely new electrical, networking, and HVAC systems tailored to the allocated open space. The NRB will coordinate with the Malawi Government's Buildings Department to secure all necessary approvals for the structural and electrical designs submitted by the Supplier.
Implementation Schedule Implementation Schedule Table (T+17 FAT, T+20 delivery, T+26 SAT, T+32 Go Live)	The Implementation Schedule compresses facility renovation (T+7 to T+18), FAT (T+17), shipping and customs clearance (T+18 to T+20) and installation and SAT (T+21 to T+26) into a 32-week programme with liquidated damages at each milestone. Can the Purchaser confirm that renovation completion and the availability of stable utility power, HVAC and network connectivity at NRB HQ are prerequisites to the installation milestone, and confirm the relief available to the Supplier where NRIS availability, customs clearance or Purchaser approvals delay a milestone?	Bidders are advised that the purchaser confirms the requirements stated in the Implementation Schedule.
Section VII → Operational Acceptance Tests OAT Table B,	The Operational Acceptance Tests require live or production-like approved citizen records, real consumables, a sustained production run of 5–10 working days and a final demonstration over an agreed 10–30-	Refer to Annex, Table A item no. 7: It states that the bidder shall successfully produce a minimum number of test cards (e.g., 500–1,000 cards) using actual production processes. Verification shall include:

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
Tests 1–5 and 17	day observation period, with $\geq 99.99\%$ data accuracy and $\leq 1\%$ card reject rate. Can the Purchaser confirm the volume of live NRIS records that will be made available for each test, who supplies the consumables and blank cards consumed during acceptance testing, whether cards produced during these tests are issued to citizens, and the precise definition and measurement method for the card reject rate?	• Data accuracy. • Print quality. • Engraving quality. • Mailing functionality. • Reporting functionality. The tests shall be conducted against the test environment of the NRIS. Cards produced during tests will not be issued to the citizens.
2.2.1 (User, Technical And Management Training)	Training is scheduled between T+25 and T+28 and Operational Acceptance Test 16 requires NRB staff to operate the entire system independently with the vendor observing only. Can the Purchaser confirm the number of trainees per stream (user, technical, management), the number of shifts to be staffed, the trainees' baseline skill level, and refresher training during the warranty period are required? whether train-the-trainer certification and	This solution will be designed and implemented by the Supplier; therefore, the Supplier is expected to provide recommendations on the minimum number of people and the prerequisite skills to operate and manage the entire system. NRB will use the recommendation to determine the number of people required for the train-the-trainer certification.
5.1 / 5.2 5.1.1.1; 5.2.1.1; 5.2.1.2	Clause 5.1.1.1 requires three years of warranty defect repair and clause 5.2.1 requires a 24×7 user hotline, Level 2 and Level 3 technical assistance and KPIs covering OEE, MTTR, MTBF and preventive maintenance compliance. Can the Purchaser state the required response and resolution times by severity, the target values for each KPI, whether on-site resident engineers are required and in what numbers, and the expected spare parts and consumables holding to be maintained on site?	Bidders are advised that the detailed response is attached as Annex A
1.6.11.2; 1.6.11.4	Clause 1.6.11.2 makes ISO/IEC 27001 certification mandatory and clause 1.6.11.4 requires FIPS 140-2/140-3 validated cryptographic modules. Can the Purchaser confirm whether these certifications must be held by the lead bidder, by each consortium member, or by the OEM of the relevant component?	The bidder's proposed team members/partner must possess the mandatory certifications required for their respective roles
1.1 / 1.6 1.1.1.1; 1.6.11.5	The Information System must comply with the Data Protection Act 2024 and GDPR principles and must support privacy impact assessment capability. Can the Purchaser confirm the data controller and data processor roles for citizen data held in the personalization system, whether any citizen data may be processed or stored outside	The NRB is the data controller for citizen data held in the personalization system. Citizen data cannot be stored or processed outside Malawi without formal clearance from the Data Protection Authority.

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	Malawi (for example during FAT at the OEM factory, for remote support, or in offsite backup)?	
1.3.1.3.1	Clause 1.3.1.3.1 requires six segregated network zones including an External Integration Zone and a DMZ. Can the Purchaser confirm whether the NRIS connection to NRB HQ is an existing dedicated link or must be provisioned under this contract, who provides and administers the perimeter firewalls and the WAN service, and whether Supplier remote administration and remote support access to the production and machine control zones will be permitted and under what controls?	The NRIS connection to the NRB HQ is a dedicated link. Because the existing perimeter firewall and WAN services are managed jointly by NRB and Malawi e-Government, external network management falls outside the scope of this procurement. Any required supplier remote access to the card personalization system must be arranged directly with NRB and e-Government.
Section I, Article 21.2	Under Section I, Article 21.2, it states that Proposers must mark confidential information. May the Purchaser confirm the format for providing these markings? For example, will a confidential footer on each page of the proposal suffice for this purpose?	Bidders are advised to use any format to indicate that the information provided is confidential.
Section III, Article 1.5	Under Section III, Article 1.5 Manufacturer's authorization, it states that a manufacturer authorization form must be completed for hardware and software components that the Proposer does not itself produce. Where certain manufacturers such as Microsoft, that are unable to provide the required authorization due to the size, structure, or nature of their operations, the Proposer respectfully requests confirmation from the Purchaser that submission of the Manufacturer Authorization Form will not be required in such circumstances.	Bidders are advised that the need for Manufacturer Authorization is critical as indicated under ITP 11.2 (j)
Section III, Article 1.5(iii),	Under Section III, Article 1.5(iii), it states where the Proposer will not establish an OEM relationship with the manufacturer, the Proposer must document that it is not excluded from sourcing these items from the manufacturer's distribution channels and proposing these items. May the Purchaser please provide examples of what documents would satisfy the Purchaser under this requirement?	Bidders are advised that an example of the documents could be distributor agreement.
Section VIII, Clause 37.2	Under Section VIII, Clause 37.2, it states that the Purchaser and the Supplier's	Bidders are advised that Clause 37.2 of Section VIII remain as provided. The borrower does not

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	subcontractors shall be named as coinsured on the Supplier's insurance policies. We request this is amended to name the Purchaser and subcontractors as an additional insured, rather than a co-insured, to ensure that insurance coverage appropriately reflects the intended allocation of risk under the contract. Naming a party as a co-insured confers full rights under the policy, including the ability to independently access coverage, submit claims, and interact directly with the insurer. Additional insured status is the established market standard for service contracts and achieves the intended protection under this clause and is what will be permitted by our insurers.	have the mandate to revise the General Conditions of the Contract unless provided for under the Special Conditions of the Contract (Section IX) of the bidding document.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
B. Functional, Architectural And Performance 1.5 Performance Requirements of the Information System 1.5.2.4.2 Mailing and Dispatch Transactions: - Envelope generation - Card-to-envelope matching transactions - Dispatch confirmation transactions - Postal tracking number generation - Delivery status updates	The proposed solution will require integration with the designated courier/postal service for the generation and validation of postal tracking numbers. Kindly identify the courier/postal service to be integrated and confirm whether the relevant API/interface specifications and integration requirements will be provided by the Purchaser.	The NRB does not have a designated courier/postal service for ID card delivery service. The solution must be ready for API integrations with a courier/postal service.
B. Functional, Architectural And Performance Requirements 1.6 Cyber Security PKI and HSM Requirements RFP Clause: 1.6.11.4 The bidder shall demonstrate compliance with: - FIPS 140-2 or FIPS 140-3 validated cryptographic modules (HSM requirement) - PKI infrastructure compliance (X.509 standards) - eIDAS-aligned digital signature standards	Please clarify the intended purpose and use of the PKI and HSM in the proposed solution	The personalization system is expected to use the Public Key Infrastructure (PKI) and Hardware Security Module (HSM) for data integrity and authenticity, and cryptographic key protection. The system is expected to print secure digitally signed QR code that contains biodata, fingerprint and face biometric details on the physical card. The Malawi e-Government. will provide the PKI solution.
C. Service Specifications – Supply & Install Items	The proposed solution will require integration with the designated courier/postal service for the generation and validation of postal tracking	The NRB does not have a designated courier/postal service for ID card delivery service. The solution must

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
2.1.4.3 Card Personalization Integration 2.1.4.3.1 The system shall: • Generate card personalization data • Produce card layouts • Print visual information • Laser engrave card information • Encode chip and/or barcode data (where applicable)	numbers. Kindly identify the courier/postal service to be integrated and confirm whether the relevant API/interface specifications and integration requirements will be provided by the Purchaser	be ready for API integrations with a courier/postal service.
C. Service Specifications – Supply & Install Items: 2.1 System Integration (to other existing systems) 2.1.4.2 Citizen Data Retrieval 2.1.4.2.1 The personalization system shall retrieve from NRIS: • Approved citizen records • Biographical information • Photograph • Signature image • Card issuance information D. Technology Specifications – Supply & Install Items 3.1 Automatic Modular Laser Personalization Systems RFP Clause # 3.1.4 Produce multilingual identity documents	Kindly provide details of all personalization features and data elements required to be printed/personalized on the front and back of the card, including the following: 1. Please provide a list of all variable text/data fields, including the required character size and maximum number of characters for each field. 2. Please specify the number of regional languages required for multilingual personalization and identify the specific fields/data elements that are required to be printed in each language. 3. Please confirm whether multiple variants or design types of National ID card will be used. 4. Please provide the all card layout/design indicating the placement of all multilingual and other personalized data fields on the front and back of the cards. 5. Please provide the required photograph size and DPI and confirm whether the image specifications shall comply with ICAO standards or a Purchaser-defined format. 6. Please provide the required signature size and DPI	Please note that this is an open national tender of a national secured system. Bidders may reference the Malawi National ID regarding the information to be printed on the card. Additional sensitive details or resources will remain confidential and will be shared exclusively with the awarded supplier at a later stage of the procurement process. The Malawi National ID features text in both English and Chichewa. Notably, Malawian citizens and foreign residents share the same blank card design, which serves as either the national ID or the foreign registration card. The ID card is ICAO compliant; therefore, the ICAO specifications apply for the photograph size and image specifications.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
D. Technology Specifications – Supply & Install Items 3.1 Automatic Modular Laser Personalization Systems RFP Clause # 3.1.5: In-line data verification of the personalized card with the verification of the optical data	Please clarify whether the proposed card personalization and mailing solution can be provided as an integrated inline setup.	Bidders must meet the card personalization and mailing specifications, which do not dictate the supplier's equipment design.
D. Technology Specifications – Supply & Install Items RFP Clause # 3.4.4: Personalization Security Features: - QR Code, and multilingual data	Please clarify the following regarding the QR Code: 1. Please advise whether the QR Code is intended solely for dispatch purposes in relation to the mailing machine or for the authentication/ verification of the applicant. 2. If no chip is required, please confirm whether a secure QR Code containing the citizen's data is required on the card. 3. Please provide the required coding format/type, size/dimensions, and placement of the QR Code on the card.	Referring to 3.4.4, the national ID is printed with a secure digitally signed QR code that contains biodata, fingerprint and face biometric information. Reference can be made on any Malawi national ID card to see the position of the QR code.
D. Technology Specifications – Supply & Install Items 3.1 Automatic Modular Laser Personalization Systems (Qty: 2) 3.1.1 Automatic Modular Laser personalization systems for Polycarbonate Smart Cards 3.1.11 The Automatic Modular Personalization Systems to be supplied under this procurement shall utilize fiberoptic or diode-based Laser & greyscale printing technology suitable	Please confirm whether the National ID card is required to be a smart card, i.e., a pocket-sized Polycarbonate (PC) card with an embedded microchip that securely stores, processes, and transmits data. If yes, kindly provide the following technical requirements: • Minimum technical specifications; • Contact/contactless interface requirements; • Operating system and application requirements; • Memory requirements; and • Cryptographic and security requirements	Please note that the specifications for the blank polycarbonate cards exclude microchips

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
for Polycarbonate Smart Card personalization operations.		
D. Technology Specifications – Supply & Install Items 3.4 Polycarbonate Cards 3.4.5 Sample Card Images (Required Submissions)	Please clarify the number of sample cards required to be submitted along with the tender proposal for evaluation and testing purposes.	Bidders are advised to refer to Section III: 1.4 - Subcontractors/vendors/manufacturers bullet No. 2 in the Table provided
D. Technology Specifications – Supply & Install Items 3.4 Polycarbonate Cards Delivery Schedule	Please confirm whether the required 2 million cards shall be delivered in a single batch or through multiple scheduled/phased deliveries. If phased deliveries are required, kindly provide the expected quantities and delivery schedule for each batch.	Bidders are advised that multiple / phased deliveries are acceptable. Bidders are however advised to ensure that each deliverable should be at least 500,000 cards. Where possible, single batch delivery of 2,000,000 is acceptable.
Section III – Evaluation and Qualification Criteria 1.1 Eligibility: Sub-Factor 1.1 (Nationality) 1.1 Eligibility: Sub - Factor 1.4 State owned Entity of the Borrower country	With reference to the Sub-Factor 1.1 (Nationality) and 1.4 State owned Entity of the Borrower country, the Documentation Required section mentions Forms ELI-1.1 and ELI-1.2 with attachments. It is requested to kindly confirm the specific forms/documents referred to as ELI-1.1 and ELI-1.2, as these forms are referenced under the eligibility criteria but we have not been able to identify or locate any forms by these names in the RFP. Your guidance will help us ensure complete compliance with the tender requirements.	Bidders are advised to refer to Section IV: Proposal Forms and use relevant forms when preparing proposals.
B. Functional, Architectural And Performance Requirements 1.3 Architectural Requirements 1.3.1.2.2.1.4 Disaster Recovery Architecture Plans: • Primary (production) environment • Secondary (DR) environment	With reference to the requirement for a Disaster Recovery (DR) site, we request clarification on the following points: 1. Is there an existing Disaster Recovery (DR) site available, or is the successful bidder expected to establish the DR site? 2. If the DR site is to be established by the successful bidder, please confirm whether it is expected to be a full-capacity mirror of the primary site, including replication of the	This project involves a single-site implementation of the card personalization and mailing system; it does not include establishing a new physical Disaster Recovery (DR) site. However, the proposed solution must be structurally built to support seamless DR integration in the future. Additionally, the Supplier must provide a robust backup and data restoration plan for all software and production data that fully utilizes the existing NRIS DR infrastructure.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
• Backup replication infrastructure • Offsite backup storage • DR synchronization mechanisms	server/data center infrastructure, or a scaled-down backup facility. In either case, kindly provide the required scope and specifications for the DR site, including the equipment, servers, hardware, infrastructure, capacity, and facility size to be provisioned. 3. Please clarify whether the printing environment is also required to be included in the DR site setup	
C. Service Specifications – Supply & Install Items 2.3 Documentation Requirements RFP Clause 2.3.1.2 Technical Documents: a) System Design Documents: i. Solution architecture document ii. Detailed system design iii. Network architecture diagrams iv. Data flow diagrams v. Physical layout drawings vi. Rack elevation diagrams vii. Facility floor plans viii. Power and cooling design	Kindly provide the existing floor plan/layout of the designated site, including the relevant dimensions and available spaces, to enable the Bidder to prepare the proposed facility layout, equipment placement, and renovation/fit-out design accurately.	The floor plan diagram has been provided by the Buildings Department.
In view of the technical clarifications sought in the queries above, we respectfully request an extension of the bid submission deadline by four to six (04–06) weeks, to allow sufficient time to incorporate the required responses and ensure that our submission is fully aligned with the RFP requirements		The amendment to the bidding document is shared to all bidders and is also available on the PPPC Website.

Annex A: Detailed Response to the following Query

5.1 / 5.2; 5.1.1.1; 5.2.1.1; 5.2.1.2

Clause 5.1.1.1 requires three years of warranty defect repair and clause 5.2.1 requires a 24×7 user hotline, Level 2 and Level 3 technical assistance and KPIs covering OEE, MTTR, MTBF and preventive maintenance compliance. Can the Purchaser state the required response and resolution times by severity, the target values for each KPI, whether on-site resident engineers are required and in what numbers, and the expected spare parts and consumables holding to be maintained on site?

1. Required Response and Resolution Times by Severity

The Supplier shall provide a comprehensive three (3) year warranty defect repair service covering all equipment, systems, components, software and associated services supplied, installed, configured or commissioned under the Contract.

The warranty service shall include diagnosis, repair, replacement, reconfiguration and/or restoration of defective equipment, components or services at no additional cost to the Procuring Entity.

The Supplier shall comply with the following minimum service levels:

Severity	Definition	Response Time	On-site Attendance	Target Resolution/Restoration
Severity 1 – Critical	Complete production stoppage; critical equipment/system unavailable; national ID production halted; major safety/security issue	≤30 minutes, 24x7	≤2 hours	≤4 hours temporary restoration; ≤8 hours permanent resolution where technically possible
Severity 2 – High	Major degradation affecting production capacity, quality or a critical subsystem, but production can continue in a limited manner	≤1 hour, 24x7	≤4 hours	≤8 hours restoration
Severity 3 – Medium	Non-critical fault with limited operational impact; workaround available	≤4 business hours	≤1 business day	≤2 business days
Severity 4 – Low	Minor defect, cosmetic issue, information request, configuration assistance or issue with negligible production impact	≤1 business day	As required	≤5 business days

The response time shall commence from the time the incident is logged with the Supplier through the designated service desk, hotline, email or other agreed communication channel.

For Severity 1 and Severity 2 incidents, the Supplier shall provide continuous effort until service is restored.

Where a permanent repair cannot be completed within the prescribed resolution period, the Supplier shall provide an appropriate temporary replacement, workaround or alternative solution capable of restoring the affected production function.

2. Proposed Level 1–4 Support Structure

Level	Support Level	Primary Responsibility	Typical Personnel	Typical Issues
Level 1 (L1)	First-Line / Operational Support	Initial logging, diagnosis and basic resolution	Facility operators, helpdesk, resident support staff	User issues, basic equipment faults, alarms, configuration checks, restart/recovery procedures
Level 2 (L2)	Technical Support	Detailed diagnosis, repair, replacement and restoration	Resident engineers / Supplier technical engineers	Hardware failures, electrical/electronic faults, software/configuration issues, production equipment faults
Level 3 (L3)	Specialist / OEM Support	Advanced technical diagnosis and specialist intervention	OEM/product-line specialists, senior engineers	Complex equipment failures, recurring faults, firmware/software defects, controller/PLC issues, major integration problems
Level 4 (L4)	Engineering / Manufacturer Escalation	Fundamental/root-cause resolution and product engineering	OEM engineering team, R&D/product development specialists	Design defects, systemic failures, unresolved L3 issues, product defects requiring engineering changes

3. Escalation Times

Severity	L1 → L2	L2 → L3	L3 → L4
Severity 1 – Critical	Immediate / ≤30 min	≤30–60 min	≤2 hours
Severity 2 – High	≤1 hour	≤2 hours	≤4 hours
Severity 3 – Medium	≤4 business hours	≤1 business day	As required
Severity 4 – Low	≤1 business day	As required	As required

4. Target Values for each KPI

a) Overall Equipment Effectiveness (OEE)

Target OEE for the production facility shall be ≥85% with a minimum acceptable monthly OEE of ≥80%.

b) Mean Time to Repair (MTTR)

Severity	MTTR Target
Critical	≤4 hours
High	≤8 hours
Medium	≤2 business days
Low	≤5 business days

c) Mean Time Between Failures (MTBF)

MTBF shall not be less than 90% of the manufacturer's specified MTBF for each critical equipment category.

For critical production equipment, no recurring failure of the same component more than twice within any rolling 90-day period without a formal Root Cause Analysis (RCA) and corrective action plan.

d) Preventive Maintenance Compliance (PMC)

PMC shall be $\geq 95\%$ monthly and 100% compliance for safety-critical and mission-critical preventive maintenance activities.

No scheduled preventive maintenance activity may be deferred without written approval from the Procuring Entity.

5. Requirement for On-Site Resident Engineers

This requirement has been indicated under Clause 5.3.

6. Expected Spare Parts Holding to be maintained on site

The Supplier shall maintain an adequate inventory of critical spare parts, components, consumables and maintenance materials at the Central Printing Facility throughout the Contract period. The minimum inventory shall include at least one replacement unit/module for each critical component identified as a potential single point of failure and not less than three (3) months' forecast consumption of commonly used maintenance and wear parts.

The Supplier shall submit a Critical Spare Parts List, including minimum stock levels, maximum stock levels, lead times, equipment applicability and OEM part numbers, for approval by the Procuring Entity prior to commissioning.

Any critical spare part consumed during maintenance shall be replenished within seventy-two (72) hours, unless otherwise approved by the Procuring Entity.

7. Spare Parts Replenishment

Any spare part used from the on-site inventory shall be replenished by the Supplier within five (5) business days, or such shorter period as may be necessary for critical components.

For critical parts, replenishment shall be done within 48–72 hours.

8. Expected Consumables Holding to be maintained on site

The Supplier shall maintain adequate stock of consumables such as lubricants, cleaning materials, filters, printer cleaning kits, fuses, belts, seals, gaskets, oils/greases, calibration materials and other OEM-recommended maintenance consumables.

It is our hope that the responses provided will assist in finalizing your proposal.

Kind Regards

IPDC Chairperson